Mark Boucher, who accused me of being a ‘silver spoon’, among other things, when we fell out over the position of the sightscreen.

‘Why don’t you just let the umpires umpire?’ I observed, with the brashness of youth. ‘Why don’t you just fucking bat?’ Boucher replied, before launching into a volley that would have made a docker blush. As he went on the attack, I learned an important lesson. To get involved in that sort of stuff you have to enjoy confrontation and be quick-witted. I was neither.

If you chirped KP, it fired him up. Sometimes he needed indignation and aggression to get him going. When I came on to the international circuit, I heard plenty of tales about the supreme stupidity of goading Steve Waugh or Brian Lara. They tended to prove their point through weight of runs, rather than the acidity of their words.

My job with Jimmy Anderson was to keep him operating on that edge, above nice but below horrible. If he was too friendly, he didn’t have that snap in his bowling. It was a sign he was not concentrating. If his head had gone, he was never going to be clinical enough to use his skills. I used to act as his barometer, fielding and shining the ball at mid-off. The idea was to get him in his red zone, where aggression was balanced by analysis. The number of wickets he took while in that perfect state of mind was remarkable; in later years he has found the knack of winding himself up without outside help, and of calming down when required. He has discovered his optimal level of performance.

There is a lot of verbal testing of players, especially when they are fresh on the scene. You could take a gamble with David Warner by having a go at him. He would always want the last laugh, the last word, and that could distract him. But there was never any certainty that it wouldn’t backfire. I prefer the term ‘managing the situation’ to ‘sledging’.

Sometimes, it is the hot spot of the game. It’s tense, the bowler and batsman are both ticking, and it flares up. I think it is brilliant, because it shows this is a game played by human beings. The phrase ‘don’t cross the line’ is a horrible expression, but it has a certain truth to it. I love watching sport, though, when there is an edge to it.

That could be a full-blooded local derby in football, where tackles are engineered to be fractionally late and deceptively painful. As a rugby fan, I mourn the fact a forward can’t get his retaliation in first by delivering a sly